TEXORA · LECTURE SHEET

Consumer Behavior in Fashion

Why people buy clothing: needs and motives beyond covering, the five-stage decision process, the forces that shape choice, and how fashions spread through a population — the demand side of every design decision in this course.

AM-4203 · FASHION DESIGN AND PRODUCT ENGINEERING · TOPIC 7 · LEVEL 4 TERM 2

1. Clothing is bought for more than warmth

A garment is a functional object and a message at the same time. Consumer research separates the motives that operate together in almost every clothing purchase: **protection and comfort** (the physical needs of the body); **modesty and social acceptance** (dressing as one's group expects); **identity and self-expression** (showing who one is, or wishes to be); **status and belonging** (marking position, or membership); **novelty and pleasure** (the enjoyment of change itself — the motive that powers the fashion cycle of Topic 1); and **practical economy** (durability, care cost, price per wear). A designer who addresses only the first motive produces uniforms; fashion exists because the others operate. The proportions differ by person, occasion and garment — which is why the same consumer buys a classic coat and a fad accessory in the same week without contradiction.

2. The consumer decision process

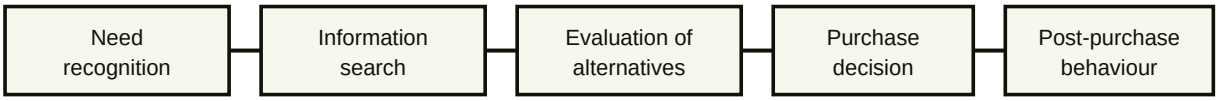


Figure 1 — The five-stage consumer decision process. Fashion purchases often compress stages 2–3 (impulse buying), which is information the designer and retailer use honestly: display and availability do the evaluating.

1. **Need recognition.** A gap is felt between the actual and the desired state — a worn-out garment, a coming occasion, a seen image. Fashion marketing works mainly here, by making a desired state vivid.
2. **Information search.** The consumer gathers options: memory, friends, shops, media, and now overwhelmingly social platforms. Fashion consumers search visually and socially more than by specification.

3. **Evaluation of alternatives.** Options are compared on the consumer's own criteria — appearance, fit, price, brand meaning, quality signals, care — weighted differently by each segment.
4. **Purchase decision.** The choice is made, subject to last influences: availability of size and colour, price promotions, the opinion of a companion.
5. **Post-purchase behaviour.** Satisfaction or dissonance follows; a satisfied fashion consumer becomes a repeater and a recommender, a dissatisfied one returns goods and warns others. This stage feeds the brand's reputation, which enters the next consumer's evaluation stage — the loop that makes quality (TE-3107) a marketing asset.

3. What shapes the choice

FACTOR GROUP	CONTENTS AND FASHION EFFECT
Cultural	The values, dress norms and occasions of the consumer's culture and subculture — the deepest and slowest-changing influences; they set what is wearable at all before any fashion question arises.
Social	Family, reference groups, workplace and peer circles: people dress substantially for the eyes of their groups, conforming to belong and differing to stand out — often in the same outfit, at different levels of detail.
Personal	Age and life stage, occupation, income, body and lifestyle: these fix the practical envelope — sizes, prices, garment types — inside which fashion choice operates.
Psychological	Perception (what is noticed), motivation (the needs of §1), attitudes and self-image: two consumers with identical envelopes buy differently because they see themselves differently.

4. How fashions spread: three theories of flow

THEORY	THE CLAIMED MOVEMENT
Trickle-down	The classical account: a style begins with the highest-status group, is copied by the group below to claim association, and descends level by level; when it reaches the bottom, the top abandons it — one engine of the fashion cycle.
Trickle-across	Styles spread horizontally within similar groups at similar speed, carried by media and fast copying: near-simultaneous appearance at many price levels leaves no time to descend.

Trickle-up (status float)	Styles originate in street, work or youth culture — workwear, sportswear, subculture dress — and are adopted upward by designers and higher-status wearers.

Modern fashion shows all three flows at once in different categories; the designer's use of the theories is diagnostic — identifying which flow a style is riding says much about its likely cycle length and price behaviour. Two roles complete the picture: **opinion leaders / fashion innovators**, the small share of consumers who adopt first and are watched by others, and the **majority groups** whose adoption or refusal at the rise stage decides whether a style becomes a fashion at all (Topic 1's acceptance, now seen from the consumer's side).

5. Using behaviour knowledge in design and product engineering

- **Segment before designing.** A range is built for a defined consumer — age, life stage, income, motives — pictured on the mood board (Topic 6); "for everyone" is not a segment.
- **Design the evaluation, not only the garment.** Consumers judge quality by signals — stitching, fabric hand, finishing (the subjects of AM-4202) — so the signals must be present where hands and eyes actually check: collar, cuff, front, hem.
- **Respect the decision timetable.** Occasion-driven needs (festivals, weddings, school terms, weather turns) concentrate demand; ranges and production (AM-4202 Study 6) are planned backwards from them.
- **Close the loop.** Returns, repairs and complaints are post-purchase data; feeding them into the next range's design is consumer research at its cheapest and most honest.

Glossary

TERM	MEANING
Consumer behaviour	The study of how individuals select, buy, use and dispose of goods to satisfy needs and wants.
Reference group	A group whose standards a consumer uses to judge their own choices, whether or not they belong to it.
Opinion leader	A person whose adoption choices are watched and copied within their circle.
Impulse buying	Purchase with the search and evaluation stages compressed to the moment of encounter.
Post-purchase dissonance	The buyer's doubt after purchase, reduced by confirmation that the choice was right.

Key points and summary

- Clothing purchases mix functional, social, identity, status, novelty and economy motives in proportions that vary by consumer and garment.
- The decision runs need → search → evaluation → purchase → post-purchase, and the last stage feeds the next consumer's evaluation through reputation.
- Cultural, social, personal and psychological factors set the envelope and the weighting of choice.
- Fashions flow down, across and up; diagnosing the flow informs cycle and price expectations; innovators start, majorities decide.

Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. A consumer buys a durable classic coat and an inexpensive short-life fashion top in one shopping trip. Explain, using §1, why this is consistent behaviour.
2. At which decision stages can (a) a shop display and (b) a friend's bad report of a brand each act? Name the stages.
3. A style appears first in skate-park clothing and two seasons later in designer collections. Which flow theory fits, and what does it suggest about the style's early price behaviour?
4. Why does §5 tell the designer to put quality signals at collar, cuff and front specifically?

Answer key

1. Different motives dominate different garments: the coat is bought mainly on protection, durability and economy (price per wear), the top on novelty and self-expression. Motive mixes are per-garment, not per-person, so the two purchases express one consistent consumer.
2. (a) The display acts at need recognition (making a desired state vivid) and at evaluation/purchase, where impulse buying compresses stages. (b) The report acts at information search and evaluation for every later consumer who hears it — post-purchase behaviour of one buyer becoming the search input of others.
3. Trickle-up (status float): adoption rises from street culture to designer level. Early on, the style typically sells at low prices in its home culture; prices and margins rise as it is adopted upward and re-issued in costlier versions.
4. Because those are the points consumers physically inspect when evaluating — the hand goes to the collar and cuff, the eye to the front; quality signals placed where evaluation actually happens are the ones that enter the decision.